

Are you really a leader if no one wants to follow you?

My District Manager told me they needed someone firm, so that's how I went in. He was wrong - and so was I.

- People Leadership
- Business Results
- Transformation Experience

The early days.

I joined the team ready to drive results. I was firm, policy-focused, and consistent. I believed clarity and accountability were the foundation for high performance. It was the same approach that had worked for me before.

I thought I was doing the right thing.

"You're doing this wrong."

"That's a policy violation."

I went in hard on policy.

"That's incorrect."

"This needs corrective action."

My District Manager publicly joked about the issue himself:

"I KNOW SHE'S A LITTLE HARSH..."

The employees were constantly negative about me.

Be consistent

Enforce policy

Set high standards

Drive results

That's when it clicked.

- It didn't matter that I'd been told to lead this way.
- I was the one choosing to keep leading this way.

The road to repair was not easy.

I apologized - to the team as a group and to employees individually. Some accepted. Some didn't. I stopped assuming that being firm meant speaking first, or last, or loudest. I questioned the importance of policy versus employee and customer experience.



Over time and with action, the environment changed:

- NPS went up.
- Sales went up.
- Turnover went down.

But no improvement would erase how I made people feel, or the environment I created for them to work in.

That lesson has stayed with me.

AT A GLANCE

- C → A
store level growth
- 16
employees
- 3
direct reports
- Multiple
bad decisions

WHY THIS STORY

Because leadership isn't only about the times I got it right. This is the story of a time my leadership was the problem — and what I did once I realized it. I had to own the impact, repair relationships, and change how I led without lowering my standards.

This story also demonstrates:

- Self-awareness
- Leadership adaptability
- Accountability
- Organizational listening
- Relationship repair

IF WE TALK, ASK ME ABOUT

- How I felt hearing my DM call me harsh.
- The employees who didn't accept my apology.
- How I rebranded.
- How I balanced changing my delivery vs changing my standards.
- How and when I coached up.
- How I felt knowing I was the manager no one liked.

WHAT I'M PROUD OF

I was willing to hear tough feedback and take personal accountability. Checking myself before coaching others became my default instead of a backup option.

MY GUIDING PRINCIPLE

Don't be the kind of leader you would also hate to work for. The way people in positions of power treat employees, especially new-to-work ones, stays longer than you might think.

IF I HAD A DO-OVER

I would shut my mouth and listen more.